MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours)/ MGU-BBA (Honours)/ MGU-BCA (Honours)

REGULAR EXAMINATION October 2026, Fifth SEMESTER
Skill Enhancement Course (SEC) - MG5SECHIS302
MUSEOLOGY IN PRACTICE

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1 hour 30 minutes **Maximum Marks: 50**

ANSWER SCHEME

Part A

Multiple Choice Questions Answer any 10 questions Each question carries 1 mark

1. a) They provide permanent records of collection information

2. No correct option provided. Artificial lighting provides controlled illumination for viewing exhibits. The printed options require correction or an appropriate moderation decision.

3. a) It supports the safe preservation, interpretation or management of collections

4. a) Object identification number

5. a) Separate public, exhibition, storage and service zones

6. b) Reduce light exposure and consider shorter display periods

7. b) Aesthetic value

8. c) Secure locking system

9. a) Follow suitable professional procedures based on the needs of the objects and visitors

10. a) General Accession Register

11. a) Proper support

12. b) It refers to conditions in a smaller area around an object

[1 × 10 = 10]

Part B

Short Answer Questions Answer any 5 questions Each question carries 3 marks

13. Explain the importance of recording provenance on a catalogue card. Recording **provenance** preserves an object's origin, ownership history and circumstances of discovery or acquisition. On a catalogue card, it supports **identification, authentication, research and interpretation**. It also assists ethical acquisition, legal enquiries and restitution claims. Reliable provenance maintains the connection between an object, its historical context and associated cultural significance.

14. Explain the relationship between museum architecture and conservation. Museum architecture supports conservation by providing suitable spaces for storage, display, examination and treatment. Building design helps regulate **light, temperature, humidity, ventilation and pollutants**,

while reducing risks from water, fire and pests. Appropriate zoning, secure access and safe circulation protect collections during everyday use, handling, maintenance and emergency evacuation procedures.

15. What is the main aim of conservation? The main aim of **conservation** is to safeguard museum objects and their significance for present and future generations. It involves **preventing deterioration, stabilising damage and preserving original materials and evidence**. Conservation enables appropriate research, interpretation and access while respecting authenticity, cultural values and the principle of minimal necessary professional intervention.

16. Why is object identification necessary before documentation? Object identification establishes what an item is before its details are recorded. Recognising its materials, form, function and distinguishing features supports **accurate classification, numbering and description**. It prevents confusion between similar objects, guides appropriate care and creates a reliable foundation for cataloguing, research, exhibition interpretation and subsequent collection management activities.

17. What is visitor circulation in a gallery? Visitor circulation is the movement of people through museum galleries, entrances, exits and connecting spaces. Planned routes help visitors follow displays, locate facilities and move comfortably. Effective circulation provides **clear signage, accessible pathways, adequate space and safe exits**, reducing congestion while supporting coherent interpretation, collection protection and an enjoyable experience.

18. What is remedial conservation? Remedial conservation involves direct actions on damaged or deteriorating objects to arrest harmful processes or strengthen fragile materials. Examples include **stabilising active metal corrosion, consolidating weakened surfaces and treating insect infestation**. Treatments require professional assessment, suitable methods and documentation, with minimal intervention to preserve the object's authenticity, significance and integrity.

19. Explain the importance of recording objects before formal accession. Recording objects before formal accession creates an **entry record** of items received for assessment, identification, loan or possible acquisition. It documents **receipt, ownership, condition, purpose and temporary location**, establishing accountability. This prevents loss or confusion and clarifies responsibilities without implying that ownership has transferred or permanent collection acceptance has occurred.

20. Explain how interactive exhibits improve visitor participation. Interactive exhibits encourage visitors to participate through activities such as handling replicas, operating models, answering questions and exploring digital content. They promote **active learning, curiosity and independent discovery**, helping explain complex ideas through experience. Accessible, well-designed interactions support different learning preferences, stimulate discussion and make museum visits engaging and memorable.

[3 × 5 = 15]

Part C

Short Essay Questions Answer any 3 questions Each question carries 5 marks

21. Explain how photography supplements written documentation without replacing it. Photography provides a visual record of an object's shape, colour, decoration, condition and distinguishing features. Images support identification, research, exhibition preparation, security enquiries and comparisons of condition over time. Multiple views and scales reveal details that written descriptions may communicate less effectively. However, photographs cannot reliably

establish **ownership, provenance, materials, measurements or cultural significance** without supporting information. Lighting and image quality may also distort appearances. **Written documentation** records contextual evidence, acquisition history, technical observations and administrative decisions. Linking dated photographs to the object's unique number therefore creates complementary evidence, strengthening documentation while preserving information that images alone cannot adequately convey.

22. Discuss the role of research, editorial review and verification in exhibition content preparation. Research establishes the factual basis of exhibition content by investigating objects, consulting reliable sources and considering relevant scholarly and community knowledge. It helps develop accurate themes, contextual explanations and meaningful narratives. **Editorial review** organises this information into clear, coherent and accessible text, adapting vocabulary, length and structure to visitors. It also removes repetition and ensures consistency across labels and panels. **Verification** checks dates, names, translations, quotations, object identifications and image captions against evidence. Uncertain interpretations should be acknowledged. Together, these processes reduce errors, prevent misleading claims and support **reliable interpretation, cultural sensitivity and public trust** in the museum's educational work.

23. Explain why respect for cultural and religious values is important when conserving museum objects. Museum objects may retain **sacred meanings, ritual functions and community relationships** beyond their material characteristics. Conservation must therefore consider cultural and religious values alongside physical preservation. Cleaning, sampling, disassembly or replacing components may remove significant substances, violate restrictions or alter an object's identity. **Consultation with communities and religious custodians** helps identify appropriate handling, access, display and treatment practices. Conservators should assess options, explain consequences and document agreed decisions. Respectful conservation avoids assuming that visual cleanliness or physical stability always takes priority. It supports **ethical responsibility, shared decision-making and trust**, preserving both material evidence and the meanings communities attach to objects.

24. Explain the importance of an Index Card in locating and identifying museum objects. An **Index Card** provides a concise reference that helps staff locate information about a museum object. Cards may be arranged by object name, material, subject, maker, geographical origin or another useful category. Each card includes the **unique identification number** linking it to the accession register, catalogue and associated records. Brief descriptions and distinguishing details help differentiate similar objects. A location reference, where maintained and updated, assists physical retrieval. Multiple indexes allow access through different search points without duplicating complete catalogue entries. Thus, index cards improve **identification, information retrieval, research and collection control**, provided that references remain accurate and consistently maintained.

25. Discuss the strengths and limitations of permanent and temporary exhibitions as museum communication strategies. Permanent exhibitions provide continuity, communicate core collections and establish a recognisable institutional identity. They support repeated educational use and justify investment in durable displays. However, outdated interpretation, limited rotation and prolonged exposure can reduce relevance and threaten sensitive objects. **Temporary exhibitions** introduce new themes, showcase research, attract returning visitors and enable loans and experimentation. Their limitations include recurring expenditure, demanding schedules and risks associated with transport and installation. Brief duration may also restrict access. Effective museum communication combines **stable narratives with changing perspectives**, reviewing permanent galleries and using temporary displays to broaden participation, respond to audiences and maintain public interest.

26. Explain why soluble salts are an important concern in the conservation of stone and porous ceramics. Soluble salts enter stone and porous ceramics through burial environments, groundwater, unsuitable storage or earlier treatments. Water carries salts into pores, where changing **relative humidity** can cause repeated dissolution and crystallisation. Crystals growing beneath surfaces exert pressure, producing **flaking, powdering, cracking and loss of decoration**. Surface deposits may also obscure appearance. Some salts absorb moisture, sustaining damp conditions and further deterioration. Conservation therefore requires identifying salt problems, controlling moisture sources and maintaining suitable environmental conditions. **Desalination**, where appropriate, requires professional assessment because treatment can damage vulnerable materials. Regular monitoring helps detect recurring deposits and prevents continuing loss of archaeological evidence.

[5 × 3 = 15]

Part D

Essay Questions Answer any 1 question Each question carries 10 marks

27. Define numbering and labelling of museum objects. Numbering assigns a unique identifier to a museum object or accession, linking it to documentation. **Labelling** attaches or applies that identifier and, where appropriate, identifying information through a suitable label or tag. Numbering systems may use sequential numbers or combinations showing accession year and entry sequence. Their structure must remain **consistent, unique and clearly documented**. Individual components require distinguishable identifiers when necessary. Numbers should connect objects with acquisition records, provenance, condition reports, photographs and movement histories. Application methods depend on **material, condition and object type**. Suitable approaches include conservation-approved barrier layers for appropriate surfaces, securely attached tags or carefully sewn textile labels. Adhesives, inks and attachment methods must not cause staining, corrosion, abrasion or structural damage. Numbers should be legible and discreet without obscuring significant features. Associated packaging should also carry identification. Together, numbering and labelling support **accountability, retrieval, security, research and reliable collection management** throughout the object's museum life.

28. Explain the importance of protecting light-sensitive objects from natural light. Light-sensitive objects, including textiles, paper, photographs, manuscripts and many pigments, undergo irreversible change when exposed to light. Natural daylight is particularly difficult to control because its intensity, direction and duration vary with weather, season and building orientation. **Ultraviolet radiation** promotes chemical deterioration, while visible light can fade colours and weaken vulnerable materials. Solar heat may also create damaging local temperature changes. Fading reduces aesthetic quality and can destroy historical information, inscriptions and decorative evidence. Protection therefore requires **excluding direct sunlight, controlling daylight and limiting cumulative exposure**. Blinds, shutters, appropriate filters and carefully positioned displays help reduce risk. However, ultraviolet filtration alone cannot prevent damage from visible light. Sensitive collections benefit from low illumination, shorter display periods, rotation and dark storage between exhibitions. Environmental monitoring and condition checks support timely adjustments. Such measures balance **public access with long-term preservation**, recognising that light damage accumulates and cannot be reversed through conservation treatment.

29. A museum is planning to display a collection of light-sensitive objects. Explain how the exhibition should be arranged to minimise light-related deterioration. An exhibition of **light-sensitive objects** should begin with a conservation assessment identifying vulnerable materials,

existing damage and suitable exposure limits. Displays should be positioned away from windows, with **direct sunlight excluded** through blinds, shutters or controlled room design. Low-ultraviolet, low-heat lighting should provide only the illumination needed for viewing. **Lux levels and exposure duration** must be considered together because light damage is cumulative. Particularly sensitive materials are often displayed around fifty lux, subject to professional assessment. Timers, occupancy sensors and visitor-operated lights can reduce unnecessary exposure. **Display rotation and shorter exhibition periods**, supported by dark storage, help manage exposure budgets. Reproductions or digital images can provide continued interpretation when originals are withdrawn. Light meters and display histories support monitoring, while condition checks detect change. Clear labels, good contrast and gradual visual adaptation improve visibility at low light levels. These arrangements balance **visitor understanding, accessibility and preservation** without promising complete protection.

[10 × 1 = 10]